

Lecture Printout: Kant's Formula of the Universal Law

Kant's own statements of The Categorical Imperative:

The Formula of the Universal Law:

"Act only on that maxim through which you can at the same time will that it should become a universal law" (Kant 1785: 73).

The Formula of the Law of Nature:

"Act as if the maxim of your action were to become through your will a universal law of nature" (*ibid.*).

Some definitions:

D1. 'M is a **maxim**' =df. 'M is a principle that an agent can adopt concerning how to act when they find themselves in a situation of a given type.'

E.g. "Whenever I am in a situation of type C,
I will perform an act-token of type A."

D2. 'Maxim M is a **universal law of nature**' =df. 'every rational creature in the world (past, present, and future) acts in conformity with the generalized version of M.'

(The **generalized version of a maxim** replaces words that refer to the particular agent [e.g. 'I'] with words that refer to all agents [e.g. 'everyone'].)

D3. 'Agent S **wills** that p comes true' =df. 'S has a sincere intention to bring it about that p comes true.'

D4. 'Agent S **consistently wills** that p & q' =df. 'S wills at time p comes true, and (at the same time) S wills that q comes true, and it is possible for p & q to be true together.'

D5. 'Maxim M is **universalizable**' =df. 'An agent who intends to act on M can consistently will that M serves as a universal law of nature.'

Kant's theory restated:

FUL: An act, x, is **morally right** if and only if the agent of x can consistently will that the maxim of x serve as a universal law of nature.

FUL': An act, x, is **morally right** if and only if the maxim of x is universalizable.

Kant's examples (two of them):

Example (2): The lying Promise.

The agent's maxim (M5): "When I believe myself to be in need of money, I shall borrow money and promise to repay it, although I know that this will never happen" (Kant 1785: 74).

Can the agent universalize the maxim?

"I then see at once that it [my maxim] could never hold as a universal law of nature and be consistent with itself, but must necessarily contradict itself. For, the universality of a law that everyone, when he believes himself to be in need, could promise whatever he pleases with the intention of not keeping it **would make the promise and the end one might have in itself impossible**, since no one would believe what was promised him but would laugh at all such expressions as vain pretenses" (*ibid.*).

- Example of a contradiction in conception.
"...The contradiction that is involved in the universalization of an immoral maxim is that the agent would be unable to act on the maxim in a world in which it were universalized so as to achieve his own purpose... [...] In willing the world of the universalized maxim and...– at the same time –willing the maxim itself, the man wills the frustration of his own end" (Korsgaard 1996: 92-93).
- Gives rise to a strict moral duty (i.e. perfect duty).

Example (4): Charity.

The agent's maxim (?) "What is [his hardship] to me? Let each be as happy as heaven wills or as he can make himself; I shall take nothing from him nor even envy him; only I do not care to contribute anything to his welfare or to his assistance in need!" (Kant 1785: 75).

Can the agent universalize the maxim?

"But although it is possible that a universal law of nature could very well subsist in accordance with such a maxim, it is still impossible to will that such a principle hold everywhere as a law of nature. For a will that decided this would conflict with itself, since many cases could occur in which one would need love and sympathy of others, and which, by such a law of nature arisen from his own will, he would rob himself of all hope of the assistance that he wishes for himself" (*ibid.*: 75).

- Example of a contradiction in will.
- Gives rise to a meritorious moral duty (i.e. imperfect duty).

Bibliography:

Kant, Immanuel (1785/1996), *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, reprinted in *Practical Philosophy*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Korsgaard, Christine (1996), *Creating the Kingdom of Ends*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.